🦬 The Heartland: Moving West: Reading

US History · Unit 2 · Level 3 (closer to the class work) · goes with Heartland Packet, American Progress, Life on the Plains, Heartland Quiz

Name: _____

Moving West: Progress for Whom?

After the Civil War ended in 1865, many Americans believed in Manifest Destiny: the idea that the United States was meant to spread across the continent. John Gast's 1872 painting “American Progress” shows this idea. A giant woman carries a schoolbook and telegraph wire west. Light follows her, and Native people and buffalo flee into the dark.

Government laws and new technology pushed settlement. The Homestead Act of 1862 gave 160 acres to any head of household who farmed the land for five years. In 1869 the Central Pacific and Union Pacific railroads met at Promontory Point, Utah. Chinese workers built much of the western line, doing the most dangerous jobs for lower pay.

Life on the Plains was hard. With few trees, families built sod houses and burned dried buffalo chips for heat. They faced isolation, blizzards, droughts and swarms of insects. Thousands of African Americans, called Exodusters, moved from the South to Kansas looking for land and safety. Cowboys, about a quarter of them Black and many of them Mexican vaqueros, drove cattle north to the railroads.

For Plains nations such as the Lakota, Cheyenne and Arapaho, expansion was a disaster. The buffalo, which gave them food, clothing and shelter, were hunted from millions to fewer than 1,000. In 1864 a Colorado militia attacked a peaceful Cheyenne and Arapaho camp at Sand Creek, killing more than 150 people. The 1868 Treaty of Fort Laramie promised the Lakota the Black Hills, but the US broke it after gold was found.

In 1876 Lakota and Cheyenne warriors led by Sitting Bull and Crazy Horse defeated Custer's 7th Cavalry at Little Bighorn. The army kept fighting, and Native nations were forced onto reservations. The Dawes Act of 1887 split reservations into small plots, and Native nations lost about two-thirds of their land. In 1890 soldiers killed about 300 Lakota at Wounded Knee, ending the major wars on the Plains.

Check your reading

1. What did Manifest Destiny mean to settlers, and what did it mean for Native nations?

2. Give two reasons settlement grew quickly after 1862.

3. Why was the loss of the buffalo so serious?